
REVISER SERIES

RV01

Subject-Verb Agreement

The Concept Guide

Read this first. Then attempt the three tests:
RV01-Easy | RV01-Medium | RV01-Hard (Exam Standard)

Road to IIM | IPMAT - JIPMAT - CUET

Before You Start

Subject-Verb Agreement (SVA) is the simplest rule in English with the largest number of traps built around it. The rule itself is one line: **a singular subject takes a singular verb, and a plural subject takes a plural verb**. Every exam question on SVA does only one thing: it hides the real subject from you, and hopes you match the verb with the wrong word.

One confusion to clear right now. With verbs, the '-s' works opposite to nouns. **Dogs** is plural, but **barks** is singular. So: *The dog barks. The dogs bark*. If the subject has the 's', the verb usually does not, and vice versa. Keep this in mind for every rule below.

This guide gives you 14 rules. Each one comes with a memory hook, wrong-vs-right examples, and the exact trap IPMAT, JIPMAT and CUET setters build from it. Read it once slowly, then attempt RV01-Easy.

RULE 1

Find the Real Subject (Ignore What Sits in Between)

The words between the subject and the verb, usually starting with *of*, *in*, *on*, *with*, *from*, *along*, *near*, are just decoration. The verb agrees with the subject, not with the noun sitting closest to it.

Memory hook: *Strike out the 'of the...' phrase. Whatever is left is the boss.*

WRONG The box of chocolates **were** kept on the table.

RIGHT The box of chocolates **was** kept on the table.

WRONG The quality of these mangoes **are** excellent.

RIGHT The quality of these mangoes **is** excellent.

EXAM TRAP: Setters deliberately place a plural noun right before the verb (chocolates, mangoes) so your ear picks the wrong number. Your ear will betray you; your eye must find the real subject.

RULE 2

Two Subjects Joined by 'And' Are Plural

When 'and' joins two different people or things, the subject becomes plural, and the verb must be plural too.

Memory hook: *And = addition = more than one.*

WRONG Rahul and Priya **is** preparing for IPMAT.

RIGHT Rahul and Priya **are** preparing for IPMAT.

RULE 3 The 'And' Exceptions: One Idea, or Each/Every

Two exceptions. First, if the two nouns joined by 'and' form one single idea or one dish or one person, treat it as singular. Second, if the compound subject starts with *each* or *every*, it is singular no matter how many nouns follow.

Memory hook: *One plate, one person, one idea = one (singular).*

WRONG Bread and butter **are** my usual breakfast.

RIGHT Bread and butter **is** my usual breakfast. (one dish)

WRONG Every student and every teacher **were** present.

RIGHT Every student and every teacher **was** present.

RIGHT The founder and CEO of the company **is** here. (one person, two titles)

EXAM TRAP: 'The founder and the CEO are here' means two different people; 'The founder and CEO is here' means one person holding both posts. Watch the second 'the'.

RULE 4 'With', 'As Well As', 'Along With' Do Not Change the Subject

Phrases like *with*, *along with*, *as well as*, *together with*, *besides*, *in addition to*, *accompanied by* only add extra information. The verb still agrees with the first subject only.

Memory hook: *Only 'and' can truly join. Everything else is a hanger-on.*

WRONG The captain, along with his players, **were** given a warm welcome.

RIGHT The captain, along with his players, **was** given a warm welcome.

WRONG Sneha, as well as her friends, **have** arrived.

RIGHT Sneha, as well as her friends, **has** arrived.

EXAM TRAP: This is among the most repeated SVA questions in Indian entrance exams. The plural crowd after 'along with' exists only to mislead you.

RULE 5 Either/Or and Neither/Nor: Agree with the Nearer Subject

When subjects are joined by *either...or*, *neither...nor*, *or*, *not only...but also*, the verb agrees with the subject closest to it. This is called the proximity rule.

Memory hook: *Or/nor: the verb obeys its nearest neighbour.*

WRONG Neither the students nor the teacher **were** present.

RIGHT Neither the students nor the teacher **was** present.

WRONG Either Ravi or his brothers **is** responsible.

RIGHT Either Ravi or his brothers **are** responsible.

EXAM TRAP: Setters flip the order of subjects to force you to re-check. Same sentence, order swapped, answer changes. Always look at the noun touching the verb.

RULE 6

Indefinite Pronouns: The Singular Family

Each, every, either, neither, one, everyone, everybody, everything, someone, somebody, something, anyone, anybody, anything, no one, nobody, nothing are all singular. Always. Even when followed by 'of the + plural noun'.

Memory hook: *Words ending in -one, -body, -thing are singular. Each and every are loners.*

WRONG Each of the students **have** submitted the form.

RIGHT Each of the students **has** submitted the form.

WRONG Neither of the answers **are** correct.

RIGHT Neither of the answers **is** correct.

EXAM TRAP: 'Each of the + plural noun + plural verb' is the single most common wrong option in exams. The 'of the students' is a Rule 1 decoy stacked on top of this rule.

RULE 7

Some, All, Most, None, Any: Look at the Noun After 'Of'

These words are flexible. They borrow their number from the noun that follows. If the noun after 'of' is uncountable, the verb is singular; if it is plural, the verb is plural. *Both, few, many, several* are always plural.

Memory hook: *SAMNA (Some, All, Most, None, Any) looks behind the 'of' to decide.*

RIGHT Some of the milk **is** spoilt. (milk: uncountable)

RIGHT Some of the apples **are** spoilt. (apples: plural)

WRONG None of the information **were** useful.

RIGHT None of the information **was** useful.

EXAM TRAP: 'None' with a plural noun can take either verb in modern usage, but exams prefer the safer match with the noun after 'of'. With uncountable nouns (information, furniture, advice), it is strictly singular.

RULE 8

Collective Nouns: One Unit or Many Members?

Words like *team, committee, jury, family, audience, government, class, crowd* are singular when the group acts as one unit, and plural when the members act separately or disagree.

Memory hook: *Acting together = is. Acting separately or divided = are.*

RIGHT The committee **has** approved the proposal. (one decision)

RIGHT The committee **are** divided in their opinion. (members differ)

RIGHT The jury **is** ready with its verdict.

EXAM TRAP: The giveaway is the rest of the sentence: words like 'divided', 'among themselves', 'their' signal separate members and a plural verb.

RULE 9 'A Number Of' vs 'The Number Of'

A number of means 'many', so it takes a plural verb. *The number of* talks about the count itself, one figure, so it takes a singular verb.

Memory hook: *A = many = are. The = the total = is.*

WRONG A number of students **was** absent today.

RIGHT A number of students **were** absent today.

WRONG The number of applicants **are** rising every year.

RIGHT The number of applicants **is** rising every year.

EXAM TRAP: This pair appears almost every year somewhere across IPMAT, JIPMAT and CUET. Memorise it as a pair, never in isolation.

RULE 10 Amounts, Distances, Time and Money Are Singular

When a plural-looking quantity is treated as one lump, one amount, one distance, one period, the verb is singular.

Memory hook: *One chunk = one verb.*

WRONG Five kilometres **are** a long distance to walk daily.

RIGHT Five kilometres **is** a long distance to walk daily.

WRONG Ten thousand rupees **were** a big amount in 1990.

RIGHT Ten thousand rupees **was** a big amount in 1990.

RIGHT Three hours **is** enough for this test.

EXAM TRAP: But if the items are counted individually, go plural: 'Five coins **are** lying on the table.' Lump = singular; separate pieces = plural.

RULE 11 Inverted Sentences: The Subject Comes After the Verb

In sentences starting with *there*, *here*, or in questions, the subject appears after the verb. Find it first, then match.

Memory hook: *'There' is never the subject. Look past the verb.*

WRONG There **is** many reasons for his failure.

RIGHT There **are** many reasons for his failure.

WRONG Here **come** the bride.

RIGHT Here **comes** the bride.

EXAM TRAP: With 'there is/are', setters put a long phrase before the real subject: 'There is, in most of our cities, several problems...' should be 'there are', because the subject is 'problems'.

RULE 12 'One of the... Who/That': Check What 'Who' Points To

In *one of the + plural noun + who/that + verb*, the verb after 'who' agrees with the plural noun, because 'who' refers to the group. But in *the only one of the... who*, the verb is singular, because 'who' now points back to that single person.

Memory hook: *One of the many who DO. The only one who DOES.*

WRONG She is one of the students who **works** hard.

RIGHT She is one of the students who **work** hard.

RIGHT She is the only one of the students who **works** hard.

EXAM TRAP: This is a Hard-level favourite because both versions sound correct. Ask: is 'who' describing the whole group, or the single person? 'Only one' locks it to the person.

RULE 13 Titles, Subjects of Study and Tricky Plural-Looking Nouns

Names of books, movies and countries are singular even if they look plural. Fields of study ending in -ics (*mathematics, physics, economics, politics*) and words like *news* are singular. But *scissors, trousers, spectacles, jeans* are plural, and *police, cattle, people* always take plural verbs.

Memory hook: *One book, one subject, one piece of news = singular. Two-legged and two-bladed things = plural.*

WRONG Mathematics **are** my favourite subject.

RIGHT Mathematics **is** my favourite subject.

WRONG The news **were** shocking.

RIGHT The news **was** shocking.

WRONG The police **has** arrested the thief.

RIGHT The police **have** arrested the thief.

RIGHT 'The Three Musketeers' **is** a classic novel.

EXAM TRAP: 'Statistics is an interesting subject' (field of study) but 'The statistics are alarming' (the actual numbers). Same word, two meanings, two verbs. Economics and politics behave the same way.

RULE 14 Fractions and Percentages: Borrow from the Noun

With fractions and percentages, the verb agrees with the noun after 'of', exactly like Rule 7.

Memory hook: *Half of WHAT? That 'what' decides the verb.*

RIGHT Two-thirds of the work **is** complete. (work: uncountable)

RIGHT Two-thirds of the students **are** present. (students: plural)

WRONG Sixty per cent of the city **were** flooded.

RIGHT Sixty per cent of the city **was** flooded.

One-Page Revision Sheet

Screenshot this page. Revise it the night before every mock.

Trigger you see	Verb	Remember
Subject + of/in/with phrase + verb	Match the subject	Strike out the middle phrase (R1)
X and Y (different things)	Plural	And = addition (R2)
One idea: bread and butter / each, every + and	Singular	One plate, one person (R3)
along with / as well as / with / besides	Match FIRST subject	Hangers-on don't count (R4)
either...or / neither...nor	Match NEAREST subject	Proximity rule (R5)
each, every, everyone, nobody, one of...	Singular	-one, -body, -thing family (R6)
some/all/most/none/any + of + noun	Match that noun	SAMNA looks behind 'of' (R7)
both, few, many, several	Plural	Always plural (R7)
team, committee, jury, family (as one unit)	Singular	'Divided/their' = plural (R8)
A number of...	Plural	A = many (R9)
The number of...	Singular	The = the total (R9)
money, distance, time as one lump	Singular	One chunk (R10)
There is/are, Here comes, questions	Match subject AFTER verb	'There' is never the subject (R11)
one of the Xs who...	Plural	'Who' = the group (R12)
the only one of the Xs who...	Singular	'Who' = that person (R12)
news, mathematics, physics, book titles	Singular	One subject, one title (R13)
police, cattle, people / scissors, trousers	Plural	(R13)
fraction/percentage + of + noun	Match that noun	Half of WHAT? (R14)

Spot Check: 10 Sentences Before the Easy Test

Pick the correct verb. No marks, no timer. If you get 8 or more right, you are ready for RV01-Easy. If not, re-read the rule mentioned in the answer and try again tomorrow.

1. The bouquet of roses (was / were) lying on the desk.
2. Neither the manager nor the workers (was / were) informed about the change.
3. Each of the participants (has / have) received a certificate.
4. The principal, along with the teachers, (is / are) attending the seminar.
5. A number of complaints (has / have) been filed this month.
6. Fifty thousand rupees (is / are) too much for this phone.
7. There (is / are) several errors in this report.
8. Politics (is / are) a dirty game, people say.
9. He is one of those writers who (believes / believe) in simplicity.
10. Most of the furniture (was / were) damaged in the move.

Answers

- | | |
|---|--|
| 1. was - Subject is 'bouquet' (R1) | 2. were - Nearest subject 'workers' (R5) |
| 3. has - 'Each' is singular (R6) | 4. is - 'Along with' doesn't count (R4) |
| 5. have - 'A number of' = plural (R9) | 6. is - Money as one lump (R10) |
| 7. are - Subject is 'errors' (R11) | 8. is - Field of study (R13) |
| 9. believe - 'Who' = those writers (R12) | 10. was - 'Furniture' is uncountable (R7) |

What next? Attempt **RV01-Easy** on the portal. Clear 70% there before moving to **RV01-Medium**, and 70% there before **RV01-Hard**. Below 50% on Easy? Come back to this guide first. The ladder only works if you climb it in order.